

China

Upstream-driven PPI, weak pass-through

Oil continued to lift PPI and support energy CPI, while core and services inflation softened, pointing to limited second-round effects amid weak domestic demand. PPI gains remained concentrated in upstream, while downstream sectors may struggle to pass-through higher input costs.

- **May: 1.2% y/y for CPI, and 3.9% y/y for PPI**
- **Bloomberg consensus forecast (Barclays): 1.3% (1.2%) y/y for CPI, and 3.9% (4.0%) y/y for PPI**
- **April: 1.2% y/y for CPI, and 2.8% y/y for PPI**

The May price data suggest oil prices continued to push up PPI inflation and energy-related components of CPI, while the impact on core and services CPI remained contained, pointing to limited second-round effects. On a month-on-month basis, PPI began to normalize alongside somewhat lower-though-still-elevated oil prices. Price declines emerged in oil and gas extraction, while price increases in chemicals, fibers, rubber, and plastics moderated.

The May PPI breakdown underscores the uneven impact of the Middle East conflict on prices. Upstream segments continued to lead, with raw materials rising by 9.2% y/y (April: 7.1%) and mining by 15.8% (April: 10.6%). While select manufacturing segments such as electrical machinery and electronics saw some price gains, overall manufacturing inflation remained more subdued at 2.3% y/y (April: 1.5%). Meanwhile, price declines in downstream consumer goods persisted (May: -0.8%, April: -1.0%), suggesting that firms are still struggling to pass through higher input costs along the value chain.

CPI was unchanged at 1.2% y/y in May, with larger support from energy in May compared with April. Despite lower oil prices in the month, a favourable year-ago base pushed domestic gasoline inflation higher (23.5% y/y versus 19.3%), lifting its contribution to headline CPI to around 0.66pp (from 0.56pp previously). Elsewhere, both core and services CPI edged lower, with continued weakness in housing rents and auto prices, reinforcing the view that soft domestic demand is limiting demand-driven reflation and preventing meaningful second-round effects.

CPI breakdown: Slower core and services inflation

Looking at the breakdown, we highlight some of the key developments in the CPI data:

- **Goods CPI inflation** rose by 1.6% y/y in May versus 1.4% in April, as faster gasoline price inflation more than offset the declines in food prices. Supported by a favourable year-ago base, domestic gasoline price inflation accelerated to 23.5% y/y from 19.3%, contributing

Ying Zhang

+852 2903 2652
 ying.zhang3@barclays.com
 Barclays Bank, Hong Kong

Yingke Zhou

+852 2903 2653
 yingke.zhou@barclays.com
 Barclays Bank, Hong Kong

Jian Chang

+852 2903 2654
 jian.chang@barclays.com
 Barclays Bank, Hong Kong

about 0.66pp to headline CPI, up from 0.56pp previously. In contrast, food CPI fell for a second month, down 1.7% y/y (April: -1.6%), subtracting 0.3pp from the headline print, mainly driven by a deeper decline in pork prices and softer fruit prices.

Core CPI eased slightly to 1.1% y/y from 1.2%, below its pre-conflict average of 1.3% in January–February. Within that, gold jewellery remained a contributor, adding 0.17pp to headline inflation, although its impact has moderated (0.2pp in April) alongside easing gold price growth. Vehicle prices continued to decline, down 1.1% y/y and 0.4% m/m. Prices in other key goods categories stayed stable, with household appliances and clothing rising 3.4% and 1.5% y/y, respectively, together adding about 0.12pp to CPI inflation.

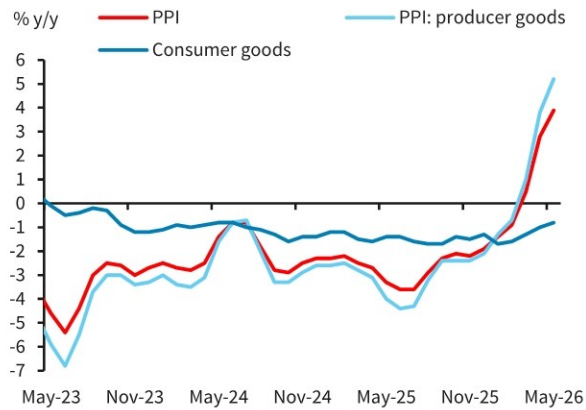
- **Services CPI inflation** edged down to 0.8% y/y in May from 0.9% in April. Travel-related service prices moderated by 0.9pp to 2.8% y/y. Prices of basic public services remained largely stable, with healthcare services (May: 3.2%, April: 3.4%), household services (steady at 1.1%) and education services (steady at 0.5%) continuing to rise. Housing rents declines held at 0.6% y/y in May, still the fastest pace of decline since January 2023, while data from the China Index Academy show rents in major cities declined at a much sharper rate of 3.2% y/y.

PPI breakdown: Notable rise in upstream sectors

May PPI advanced for a second month, rising by 3.9% following a 2.8% gain in April. The notable improvement was supported by surging prices in non-ferrous metals and energy-related sectors, with rising copper prices amid strong AI and green tech-related demand and supply concerns amid the Middle East conflict. On a m/m basis, the increase in PPI moderated to 0.5%, after picking up 1.7% in April, which was the fastest pace since late 2021.

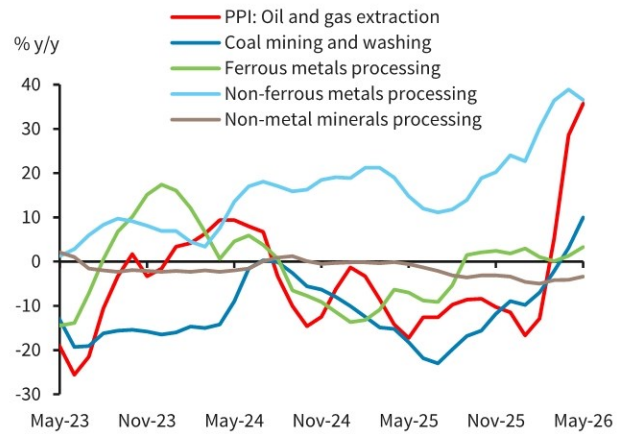
Looking at the breakdown, PPI gains remain highly concentrated in upstream sectors. The producer goods PPI for mining (May: 15.8% y/y, April: 10.6%, March: 2.0%) and raw materials (May: 9.2%, April: 7.1%, March: 1.1%) accelerated, while manufacturing PPI picked up at a much measured pace (May: 2.3%, April: 1.5%, March: 0.9%). According to the NBS, non-ferrous mining and processing led the upside, alongside strong gains in coal and selected manufacturing segments such as electrical machinery and electronics, contributing 2.56pp to the headline PPI print (April: 2.05pp). Energy and chemicals were another key driver, with oil and gas extraction, refined fuels, and chemical products all saw strong price increases, jointly adding close to 2pp to the headline print, again with a larger contribution than in April (1.5pp). In contrast, the consumer goods PPI remained in deflation, despite some narrowing (May: -0.8%, April: -1%, March: -1.3%).

FIGURE 1. PPI continued to accelerate...



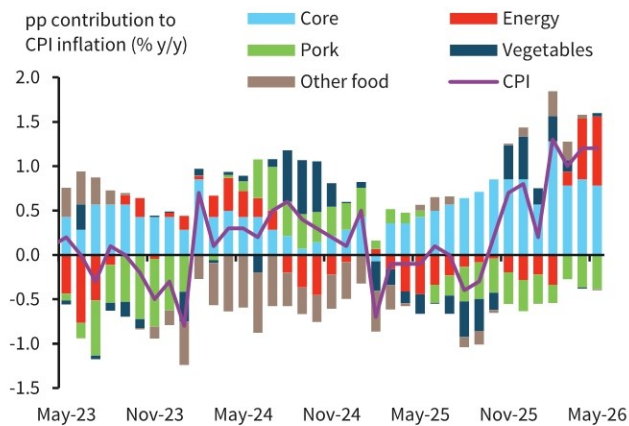
Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 2. ...led by non-ferrous metals and energy-related sectors



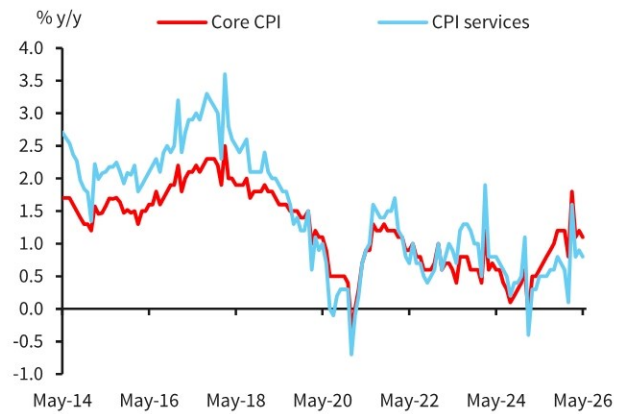
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FIGURE 3. Energy remains a key driver of headline CPI...



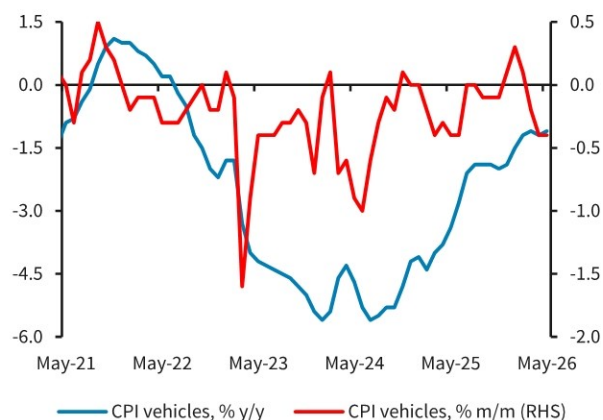
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FIGURE 4. ...while core and services CPI moderated



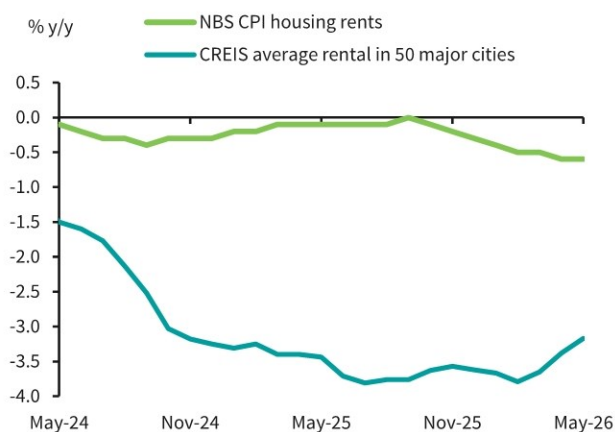
Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 5. Auto prices continued to drop...



Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 6. ...and so did housing rentals



Source: Wind, Barclays Research

FIGURE 7. CPI breakdown and PPI

	May-26	Apr-26	Mar-26	Feb-26	Jan-26	Dec-25	Nov-25	Oct-25	Sep-25	Aug-25	Jul-25	Jun-25	May-25
CPI %y/y													
Headline	1.2	1.2	1.0	1.3	0.2	0.8	0.7	0.2	-0.3	-0.4	0.0	0.1	-0.1
Headline (%m/m)	-0.1	0.3	-0.7	1.0	0.2	0.2	-0.1	0.2	0.1	0.0	0.4	-0.1	-0.2
Services	0.8	0.9	0.8	1.6	0.1	0.6	0.7	0.8	0.6	0.6	0.5	0.5	0.5
Services (%m/m)	-0.1	0.5	-1.1	1.1	0.2	0.0	-0.4	0.2	-0.3	0.0	0.6	0.0	0.0
Goods	1.6	1.4	1.3	1.1	0.3	1.0	0.6	-0.2	-0.8	-1.0	-0.4	-0.2	-0.5
Goods (%m/m)	-0.2	0.1	-0.3	0.8	0.2	0.3	0.1	0.2	0.3	0.1	0.2	-0.1	-0.3
Food	-1.7	-1.6	0.3	1.7	-0.7	1.1	0.2	-2.9	-4.4	-4.3	-1.6	-0.3	-0.4
Food (%m/m)	-0.4	-1.6	-2.7	1.9	0.0	0.3	0.5	0.3	0.7	0.5	-0.2	-0.4	-0.2
Core (excluding food and energy)	1.1	1.2	1.1	1.8	0.8	1.2	1.2	1.2	1.0	0.9	0.8	0.7	0.6
Core (excluding food and energy, %m/m)	-0.1	0.2	-0.7	0.7	0.3	0.2	-0.1	0.2	0.0	0.0	0.4	0.0	0.0
Non food	1.9	1.8	1.2	1.3	0.4	0.8	0.8	0.9	0.7	0.5	0.3	0.1	0.0
Non food (%m/m)	-0.1	0.7	-0.2	0.8	0.2	0.1	-0.2	0.2	-0.1	-0.1	0.5	0.0	-0.2
Housing	-0.2	-0.2	-0.2	-0.2	-0.1	-0.2	0.0	0.1	0.1	0.1	0.1	0.1	0.1
Recreation	1.3	1.3	1.1	2.0	0.0	0.9	0.8	0.9	0.8	1.0	0.9	1.0	0.9
Transportation	5.4	4.6	0.9	-0.7	-3.4	-2.6	-2.3	-1.5	-2.0	-2.4	-3.1	-3.7	-4.3
Medical	2.1	2.2	1.9	1.9	1.7	1.8	1.6	1.4	1.1	0.9	0.5	0.4	0.3
Clothing	1.4	1.5	1.6	1.9	1.9	1.7	1.9	1.7	1.7	1.8	1.7	1.6	1.5
Household facilities	1.8	1.4	1.5	2.8	2.6	2.2	2.1	1.9	2.2	1.8	1.2	0.7	0.1
PPI % y/y	3.9	2.8	0.5	-0.9	-1.4	-1.9	-2.2	-2.1	-2.3	-2.9	-3.6	-3.6	-3.3
PPI % m/m	0.5	1.7	1.0	0.4	0.4	0.2	0.1	0.1	0.0	0.0	-0.2	-0.4	-0.4

Source: Wind, Barclays Research

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